

Japanese prints

During Japan's Edo period (1615–1868), the country was economically stable but closed to foreign trade. In the 1660s, Japanese artists had begun painting *Ukiyo-e*, or 'pictures of the floating world', depicting the pleasure districts of Edo (modern Tokyo). In c.1675, Hishikawa Moronobu (1618–94) produced the first *Ukiyo-e* woodblock prints and later, Suzuki Harunobu (1725–70) made full-colour 'brocade prints'. Katsushika Hokusai (1760–1849) created *Thirty-Six Views of Mount Fuji*, which includes the famous *Great Wave off Kanagawa*, and Andō Hiroshige (1797–1858), also known for landscapes, produced *The Fifty-Three Stations of the Tōkaidō* and *The Sixty-Nine Stations of the Kiso Kaidō*.

After 1853, Japan resumed trade with the West, and the prints, with their asymmetrical compositions, flat colours and absence of perspective, inspired countless Western artists and designers. The resulting wave of Japonisme (see [here](#)) articulated by individuals including James McNeill Whistler and Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec, influenced several later art and design styles.



Hokusai, *Great Wave off Kanagawa*, c.1832